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Gender Change, Organizational Change, and Gender Equality Strategies¹

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INTRODUCTION

Change is at the heart of gender studies and the field of gender, work, and organization is no exception to that. Since second-wave feminism provided the impetus to question women's and men's positions in society, an ever increasing flow of research has problematized the gendered division of labor and made a plea for gender equality. A quest for change is thus more or less central to the field. Despite many initiatives aimed at changing organizations into gender-balanced or gender-equitable workplaces, change is slow at best. Only from a historical perspective, when one looks back a few decades, does it become clear that changes toward equality have indeed occurred, at various levels (welfare states, organizations, and the attitudes of people).

Work by Mills (2006) on gender in the airline industry illustrates that gender change does occur. In the twenty-first century, direct discrimination by sex and sexual harassment are forbidden by law, at least in many Western countries. Virtually all occupations are now formally open to women as well as men, although the first women to enter certain masculine occupations still make headline news. Nonetheless, a depressing amount of evidence on asymmetries between the sexes persists in economic, cultural, and political domains (Fraser, 2009).

Studies of gender inequality in paid work and organizations offer insightful descriptions of patterns of gender inequality. A good example is documented in a *leaky pipeline* analysis that goes beyond description of the absence of women in top positions to diagnose how organizations systematically lose women on their way to the top (Osborn, Rees, Bosch, Hermann, Hilden, and Mason, 2000; Pell, 1996; Van den Brink, 2009). While knowledge about gender inequalities has grown, we

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know less about how to change inequalities, particularly about the actual practices of change that are most effective. Scholarly research tends to focus on the description, analysis, or deconstruction of the *status quo* (depending on the theoretical preferences of the author) while it remains disconnected from actual initiatives of gender transformations. Although many scholars simultaneously engage in putting their thoughts into practice in consultancy and organizational change projects, we perceive a gap between scholarship and these knowledge-based advocacy activities. From our experience as critics and designers of gender equality policies, we understand that policy-making and the academy are different worlds. The results of applied research conducted at the behest of third parties often do not find their way into academic debates. And complex theoretical notions often fail to work well in practical settings. Gender equality policies are developed in a context where theory is thin and actions are based on the common sense of practitioners fuelled by a mix of political fashions, self-acclaimed best practices, scholarly work, time constraints, and the urge to show visible success.

This chapter provides an overview of attempts developed over many years to facilitate change in organizations and societies toward greater gender equality. It discusses the aims and content of strategies and interventions and assesses their performance in practice on both discursive and material levels. To do so, we invoke insights from political science, organization studies, and gender studies. We analyze the strategies for gender change on two dimensions: from the individual to the structural level and from a narrow to a (more) wide-ranging scope. We also identify gaps in knowledge that hinder the impact of interventions aimed at enhancing gender equality. The chapter then turns to organization change theories and gender theories to examine key impediments to gender-related change: the challenges of planning gender-related change, efforts oriented to incremental change, resistance to gender equality, the issue of intersectionality, and the need for voice. We end by identifying a new approach to gender change in organizations that sets out to cope with these impediments, which we call the genderXchange strategy.

AN OVERVIEW OF THE QUEST FOR ORGANIZATIONAL CHANGE TOWARD GENDER EQUALITY

Strategies for gender equality are characterized by a process of continuous innovation. From the birth of gender equality policies in the 1970s, policy-makers and academics who follow these policies critically have sought to identify the ideal content and ideal form of change strategies (see, for example, [Bacchi, 1996](#); [Jenson, 2008](#); [Liff and Cameron, 1997](#); and [Nentwich, 2006](#)). Ongoing theoretical debates and problematic constructs also characterize the history of this effort ([Squires, 2007](#); [Walby, 2005](#)), which limits knowledge about how to effectively combat gender inequalities.

Two debates have had an impact on the strategies for gender change: (a) sameness–difference and (b) structure–agency. The debate on sameness and difference focuses on the question of whether women are the same as or different from men. The debate on structure and agency pertains to the question of whether social inequality

is the effect of societal structures or the effect of individual actions. Rooted in old controversies in social theories between voluntaristic and deterministic paradigms, gender scholars debate how individual or collective actors are able to escape structures that are theoretically conceived as the unintentional but inescapable result of human activity. Applied to organizational change goals, this means that gender equality strategies primarily target individuals *or* structures and only rarely transcend this dichotomy.

The classical difference argument is that women *essentially* differ from men in nearly every meaningful respect – biologically, intellectually, emotionally, and behaviorally. These differences result in an undervaluing of the feminine in organizations (among other contexts) which, in fact, should be valued positively. According to this argument, women have a special contribution to make to work and organizations because their different experiences, values, characteristics, behavior, feelings, and thoughts provide them with qualifications that are much needed in organizations and that men often fail to offer. [Fletcher \(1999\)](#), for instance, speaks of women's relational skills and ability to connect to others in contrast to men's deficits in these respects.

The perspective of sameness, on the other hand, is that any differences between the genders are caused by patterns of discrimination and prejudice against women versus privilege and favoritism toward men. The basic argument is that no essential gender differences exist in abilities, qualifications, or work orientations that can account for occupational segregation, wage gaps ([Padavic and Reskin, 2002](#)), and other deficits regularly experienced by women at work. Failing to use the full potential of women employees is practically inefficient, economically unwise, and a formidable waste of talent. In its focus on the similarities of women and men, the sameness perspective tends to overlook differences between women that are based on social identity categories, including ethnicity, age, and social class and their intersections. Heated debates about equality and diversity do not prevent these notions from being used to underpin strategies for change that have developed over the years in various disciplines ([Jewson and Mason, 1986](#); [Kirton and Greene, 2005](#); [Rees, 1998](#); [Walby, 2005](#)).

A TWO-DIMENSIONAL COMPARISON

Although parallel developments in different disciplines can be confusing, on the issue of gender equality policies and feminist interventions, the similarities exceed the differences. Indeed, the similarities are striking. Our review of strategies for gender change is inspired by [Jewson and Mason's](#) work on equality policies (1986), which contrasts liberal and radical equality policies, and by the work of [Kirton and Greene \(2005\)](#) who add managing diversity and gender mainstreaming to the mix. Additionally, we review the four feminist intervention strategies for change that are noted by [Meyerson and Kolb \(2000\)](#). We review these approaches to gender change in order to compare them on two dimensions. As noted earlier, the first is the classic individual–structure distinction and the second pertains to the scope of the changes that are envisioned, that is, consisting of inclusion, re-valuation or transformation.

TABLE 17.1: A two-dimensional model of strategies for gender change.

	<i>Inclusion</i>	<i>Re-valuation</i>	<i>Transformation</i>
Individual	LIBERAL Equip the woman Create equal opportunity	MANAGING DIVERSITY Value difference	
Structural	RADICAL Create equal opportunity		GENDER MAINSTREAMING Post-equity

Individual/inclusion. At this level, strategies are focused on individual women maximizing their potential to survive and thrive in organizations and societies (see Table 17.1). A *liberal equality* strategy (Jewson and Mason, 1986) stresses the need for equal opportunities for all individuals and insists on formal equal treatment for all, regardless of social categories such as gender, ethnicity, social class, and age. This strategy sees inequality between men and women in organizations as the core problem and the solution to the problem is an improvement in the position of women.

The strategy of ‘*equip the woman*,’ identified by Meyerson and Kolb (2000), also assumes a liberal vision of work organizations. In particular, it rests on the assumptions that jobs are acquired through merit alone and that women and men have equal opportunity to acquire and succeed in all jobs. Change is geared towards improving the qualifications of women so they are better equipped to compete with men. The kinds of exemplary measures that have the potential to produce this result include management development and mentoring and/or training programs that will teach women critical skills and rules of the game (that men, presumably, already know).

In individual strategies like these, the agency of individuals is at the center of the remedy. It is primarily women who are targeted, who must be ‘tinkered’ with (Rees, 1998), so they can become more productive and successful workplace participants. Men also could be ‘equipped’ with new capacities and skills to enable them to function better in gender equal organizations (and societies) but men are not typically targeted. In brief, these interventions target only one-half of the players and not the game, thus explaining why individual inclusion strategies have produced little concrete change. If equality means that women and men should get equal opportunities to become ideal workers for their organizations, this is at best a meager form of gender equality. This version of organizations is exposed by Nancy Fraser (2009) as reflecting an unsavory liaison between second-wave feminism and neoliberal capitalism that thrives on the principle of flexible labor participation and low wages for women.

And yet, many laws, rules, and regulations that were developed in response to the call for equal opportunities have had a positive impact on organizations in challenging direct discrimination based on a worker’s sex. Equal pay and fair employment procedures for recruitment and promotion may not be realized yet but thanks to equal opportunity strategies of the individual/inclusion type, they are recognized as worth striving for. Likewise, the call for equal opportunities and special programs

for women have helped to increase the number of women in top organizational positions. In the US, for example, mentoring appears to be more fruitful for black women while networking has proved more effective for white women (Castilla, 2005; Kalev, Dobbin, and Kelly, 2006: 604). While neither strategy has improved the lot of all women, research evidence suggests that each can be effective, at least for some women and to a degree.

Individual/re-evaluation. A second set of strategies focused on the individual stresses the need to re-evaluate the notion of sameness and difference. These strategies celebrate gender differences, seeing them as a resource for organizations and for society. Gender inequality is viewed implicitly as a result of failing to value the capacities and life experiences of women while valorizing those of men. (What exactly constitutes 'feminine' or 'masculine' capacities is rarely addressed in these strategies.) A *value difference* strategy calls for acknowledging the special contributions of feminine styles and qualities such as listening, collaborating, and communicating in organizations (Fletcher, 1998). The aim is to change the hierarchical order in organizations that *values the masculine over the feminine* (see Martin (1993) on how feminine and feminist management strategies differ). The strategy builds on feminist standpoint theory (Harding, 2004) which produces knowledge based on the actualities of women's everyday lives and uses that knowledge politically to question the practices of powerful institutions. Our position is that a call to reevaluate the feminine unaccompanied by a corrective revaluating of the masculine is doomed to failure. As Fletcher's research (1999) on engineers in the Xerox Corporation showed, men routinely failed to view their women colleagues' 'feminine contributions' as real work.

Managing diversity, a strategy that emphasizes each individual's unique contribution to an organization, similarly values employee diversity. Gender diversity, the somewhat awkward term for gender differences in this model, is recognized as an important diversity dimension along with cultural and other forms of diversity. In this framework, everyone is diverse – not only women, minorities, the elderly, or handicapped. Even men are diverse. Furthermore, differences are positive. Heterogeneity is valuable and can be utilized to enhance an organization's effectiveness. Within a managing diversity strategy, gender equality is a means to the business goal of maximizing profits. However, measures associated with actually assessing the effectiveness of this strategy are mostly intangible. Mission statements about the value of an inclusive organization culture are popular but how one is achieved is far from clear (Kunda, 1992).

Individual re-valuation strategies differ from individual inclusion strategies in demanding a revaluation of classic femininity, but they similarly disregard organizational and societal structures as the causes and conditions for including women (the first approach) or re-evaluating difference. Both of these strategies fail to address gender inequalities. A business case rationale inspires a 'happy diversity' discourse (Hoobler, 2005) that accentuates the sameness of individuals rather than a positive valuation of their differences. Reliance on business case goals again plays a tune consistent with neoliberal capitalism. An emphasis on individual contributions prevents understanding of the processes of power, privilege, and subordination. Even when managing diversity makes difference a positive issue, often it reinforces stereotypes and fails to challenge the fact that women and minorities remain in subordinate positions. This is exemplified in diversity training programs that teach participants

about communal women and agentic men ([Rudman and Glick, 1999](#)). Nevertheless, individual revaluation strategies have fostered a discourse about the special contribution to organizations that women and minorities can make. A study of the Dutch police force ([Boogaard and Roggeband, 2010](#)) shows how this discourse can be used to illuminate the contributions of police women to the core work of police departments when their relational skills help de-escalate tense situations.

To no one's surprise, we do not find strategies that focused on the individual level calling for transformation of the organization or society. The absence of strategies to 'equip' men for more gender equal workplaces and societies and the focus on 'classic femininity' (re)installs traditional gender categories without challenging the unequal power relations between them. This absence prohibits a *transformative* approach and thus prevents realization of true gender equality.

Structural/inclusion. A structural strategy that aims for including women, the *radical equality* strategy, focuses attention on a 'reset' of opportunity structures for women that resembles the liberal structural strategy of *creating more opportunities*. The *radical equality* strategy does not stop at fostering equality of opportunity for women but makes equality of outcomes a central goal ([Kirton and Greene, 2005](#)). This strategy has an eye for the systematic discrimination of social groups and for stereotypes and prejudices that prevent recognition of the merits of those groups. This strategy utilizes measures geared towards positive discrimination, for example, by applying quotas and preferential treatment to realize desired equality outcomes. The label of 'radical' expresses that this is a contested model. It requires direct interventions – aimed at a just division of advantages for women and men – that are often perceived as unfair ([Bacchi, 1996](#)).

In many countries and under European law, measures such as quotas are outlawed because they are presumably discriminatory against men. Nevertheless, direct interventions including quotas have proved to be effective at placing gender equality change on the political agenda and at actually producing positive change. Quotas for women in politics have spread to more than 100 countries around the globe ([Krook, 2008](#)). Quotas that target the representation of women on the boards of governing bodies have been implemented in several Nordic countries and quotas in Norway have also spread to the private sector ([Tienari, Holgersson, Merilainen, and Hook, 2009](#)). Quota laws have been also found to be just mildly effective in increasing women's presence ([Htun and Jones, 2002](#)). That quotas have been widely implemented despite resistance shows that women have gained in political power ([Dahlerup, 2006](#)).

A *create equal opportunity* strategy acknowledges the existence of structural barriers, sees organization structures as the key problem, and wants to change the sloped playing-field into a level playing-field. This strategy addresses biased recruitment, biased promotion, and biased evaluation procedures ([Martin, 1996](#)). Typical examples of measures are transparent recruitment practices, flexible work arrangements, and alternative career paths. These interventions have contributed to the quality of working life for both men and women and have had an impact on the numerical representation of women in organizations. However, a focus on structure alone can lead to alternative career paths and/or time issues for women [the so-called mommy tracks, ([Benschop and Doorewaard, 1998](#))] that are restricted by and bound to gendered social norms. Removing structural barriers without addressing underlying cultural

norms related to gender, work, and organization lowers the odds of this strategy for creating positive gender change (Mescher, Benschop, and Doorewaard, 2010).

A usual criticism of structural inclusion approaches is that they are too weak to abolish gender inequality. However, this criticism stops short of considering what would happen to an organization (or society) if all women were fully included. Would gendered norms and stereotypes still exist? Would gender remain a structuring principle if women were structurally included in all realms of society? Perhaps the problem with this approach is that it often involves women's 'structural inclusion' in only one domain, that is, the economy. But perhaps full inclusion in one domain can provide a tipping point for producing change in other domains (Walby, 2009). Women's full inclusion across the economy, civil society, and polity could perhaps bring about true transformation, thus blurring the distinction between inclusion and transformation.

A structural revaluation strategy is not de facto a strategy for true gender change. There are no empirical examples of what Squires calls a strategy of reversal (Squires, 2007), a strategy of turning societies or organizations upside down by organizing them according to feminine values. Some examples exist of feminist organizations that take issue with traditional hierarchies and capitalist masculinist ways of organizing (Iannello, 1992) but they have not been applied to broader strategies for gender change.

Structural/transformation. Last but not least, we address structural transformation strategies that are represented to be 'ideal' and 'transformative' in the sense that they address and try to change gender as a structure.

Gender mainstreaming is a structural transformation strategy that aims to transform organizational processes and practices by eliminating gender biases from existing routines. It involves regular organizational actors in the transformation process (Council of Europe, 1998). This strategy introduces new responsibilities for policy-makers who are on the 'inside' and who try to identify and change the routines and fossilized norms that (re)produce gender inequality (Eisenstein, 1996). To be successful, they must call on and cooperate with gender experts to confront and challenge policies that foster gender inequality at work. Gender mainstreaming thus mobilizes many people to engage in changing gender relations in different areas in organizations (Stratigaki, 2005). Many scholars and activists agree that gender mainstreaming is potentially a transformative strategy (Verloo, 2005).

However, the social dynamics required for this strategy to be effective asks feminists and policy-makers to cooperate to the point that 'gender' and 'the mainstream' agree to common problem definitions. This practice entails processes of stretching and bending problem definitions and compromises to cope with resistance and compromise, actions that can (and at times do) undermine the transformative potential of gender mainstreaming (Benschop and Verloo, 2006; Lombardo, Meier, and Verloo, 2008). This resonates with the 'dual agenda' challenge noted by Ely and Meyerson (2000) in the context of the post-equity strategy (see below). A key critique of gender mainstreaming concerns the inadequate economic, political, and bureaucratic support that prevents structural transformation success. McGauran (2009) points to bureaucratic characteristics that foster an integrationist, but not transformative, implementation of gender mainstreaming. Gender mainstreaming lacks a clear and concise methodology for achieving its goals. Also, policies and practices routinely

diverge in ways that prevent or discourage genuine change (Eveline, Bacchi, and Binns, 2009). Regarding the methods for accomplishing gender mainstreaming, technocratic tools such as gender impact assessment and gender budgeting techniques outnumber the participatory tools needed for feminist groups and marginalized women's voices heard to be heard (Walby, 2005; Verloo, 2005). Gender mainstreaming is critiqued also because it fails to address feminist theories of intersectionality and privileges the category of gender over other social categories such as ethnicity or class. Sometimes, a shift to diversity mainstreaming is propagated (Hankivsky, 2005) in regard to intersectionality but this term is contested because it is associated with individualizing and apolitical tendencies (Eveline, Bacchi, and Binns, 2009) that fail to produce gender equality.

Post equity. Ely and Meyerson (2000) propose another structural transformation strategy. The 'post equity' strategy sees gender as an axis of power and core organizing principle that shapes social structures, knowledge, and identities. Their work addresses challenges to the ongoing social construction of gender at work. The central problem, as viewed in this strategy, is the processes that produce gender inequalities as part of everyday organizational routines and interactions (Acker, 1992). The strategy advocates action-research projects that apply a specific form of critique focused on how gender inequalities are detrimental to organizational performance, followed by experiments that interrupt gendering processes while improving work effectiveness, and concluded by narratives about the experiments and their successes (Ely and Meyerson, 2000). Change depends not on the action of one actor but on fruitful collaboration between researchers and organization members who understand and accept a feminist critique and interventions that stem from that critique. Ely and Meyerson (2000) note how a *dual agenda of gender equality and business success* is difficult to maintain because of the dominance of business issues over gender issues. Yet a dual agenda focus may foster a seductive discursive strategy that aligns to good effect with a managerial discourse about organizational performance (Benschop and Verloo, 2006). And yet, the risk of 'losing gender' to business issues is real, especially when targeted organizational routines serve the interests of those in power.

The *post equity* and *gender mainstreaming* strategies share some similarities, among them their theoretical promise but problematical chances for implementation. Both lack a deep theoretical understanding of how change can happen without violently disrupting society or how *revolution without a revolution* can come about. They recognize a need to transcend the individual level (sometimes to the extent of overlooking this level altogether) but are poorly developed when it comes to assigning duties to particular actors, the best ways to initiate change, the most promising sequencing of change, specification of smaller and bigger steps, and a way to take intersecting inequalities into account. All too often, they call for changing everything everywhere by everyone.

Discussion. Upon reviewing a range of strategies, we now note some absences and tensions in recommended methods for producing gender equality change. First, most strategies are not informed by social theories of change that could help articulate how change in gender relations can be realized. Second, while gender change in practice entails an eclectic amalgam of strategies, in theoretical work the strategies are mostly discussed as if they do not and cannot co-exist. The sad result is

that this obscures reflection on the potential effect of combinations of strategies in terms of transforming organizations to foster gender equality. Exceptions include Dickens' (1999) plea for a tripod of business case, legal, and social regulation strategies as a sounder basis for equality action and Booth and Bennett's (2002) plea for a three-legged stool where equal rights, positive action, and gender mainstreaming are pursued at once. Third, feminist academics express a preference for structural transformation but they also present it in their critiques as 'mission impossible.' Their transformative approaches are unattractive to policy-makers and practitioners because they are bereft of practical instruments and strong in 'scary radicalism,' thus prompting fear and resistance. Fourth, intersectionality is, as a rule, present only in watered-down individual strategy solutions and thus women members of disadvantaged groups and also most men see little that relates to their welfare. Finally, the voice of marginalized groups is hard to find in the various change strategies. We explore these issues further in the next section.

GENDER CHANGE AND ORGANIZATION CHANGE?

Most organizational change theories that speak to changes in gender equality pay a great deal of attention to obstacles hindering change and portray genuine change as complex, difficult, and problematical (Greenwood and Hinings, 2006). Three themes are relevant to gender change: (a) the possibility of planned change, (b) the likelihood of revolutionary (or fundamental) change that will turn an organization in a new direction, and (c) resistance to organizational change. As useful as organization change theory might be, gender blindness lowers its utility and keeps key issues of gender change off the agenda. Intersectionality and voice for marginalized groups are such key issues that have a profound impact on gender change as well.

The issue of *planned and unplanned change* is critical to an understanding of gender equality strategies in organizations. Our review of diverse models aimed at producing positive gender change underscores that point. Organizational change is complex and unforeseen consequences are bound to happen (Burke, 2002). This point is no different relative to gender than to culture or anything else. Connell (2006) questions whether the processes of gender change can be intentionally steered, that is, whether an agenda of transformation can be successfully implemented. And yet, a strong belief exists in the field of gender, work, and organization that systematic, planned change is needed to produce organizational transformations toward greater gender equality. The US ADVANCE program is an example of a planned comprehensive change program (Bilimoria, Joy, and Liang, 2008). The goals of planned change easily devolve into managerialism, however, because a mechanistic understanding of change (Sturdy and Grey, 2003) prompts development of detailed regulations, controls, and monitoring. Managerialism elevates control and regulation as the sole factors leading to effective and successful change. In declaring content and understanding irrelevant, managerialism fosters 'doing the paper instead of doing the deed' (Ahmed, 2007), creating additional bureaucracy instead of meaningful change. It also lures feminist change agents into considering themselves as saviors of the organization, clearly a belief beyond reality (Parker, 2002).

Regarding *revolutionary versus incremental change*, the gender mainstreaming and post-equity strategies seek to transform organizations via revolutionary change whereas other strategies focus on an incremental or more evolutionary process. Indeed, most of the latter strategies frame organizational changes as continuous, small improvements rather than as strong disruptions reflecting revolution. Cockburn (1989) speaks of the short and long agenda for change, recognizing a need for both incremental and radical gender change in organizations. [Meyerson and Fletcher \(2000\)](#), in contrast, advocate for incremental gender changes that they call 'small wins.' First, they state that the nature of gender inequality in organizations calls for incremental changes because direct gender discrimination has been adequately dealt with and remaining gender inequalities are intertwined with everyday work practices.

A second reason to prefer small changes over big ones is the issue of *resistance to change*. A small wins strategy is 'a way to chip away barriers that hold women back without sparking the kind of sound and fury that scares people into resistance' ([Meyerson and Fletcher, 2000](#): 128). Resistance to change is typically strong when an organization's cultural norms, beliefs, attitudes, and values are the target of change efforts. This is certainly the case with projects that target the gender bias in organizational routines ([Benschop and Verloo, 2006](#)). It is thus unsurprising that studies of gender change report extensive resistance. Resistance comes in many forms and shapes. Examples include men who resist women's entry into previously masculine domains, challenges to the authority of women managers, denying problems with gender in the organization (Connell, 2006; Martin, 2006), requests for research or training in order to avoid action, and attempts to escape involvement in gender change efforts ([Benschop and Verloo, 2006](#)).

In the organizational change literature, a direct approach to changing organization cultures is not advised because this approach triggers strong resistance and emotions. Rather, some scholars urge change agents to start with *behavioral change* in hopes they will trigger favorable *changes in attitudes* and values (Burke, 2002). A similar plea is made in the gender mainstreaming literature with Stark (1998) advocating the *organization of obligations* because that approach is more effective than trying to change attitudes. In our experience, Stark's claim fails to hold. Feminist change agents should not assume that organizing behavioral changes will ensure gender equality ([Benschop and Verloo, 2006](#): 30). We have seen too many implementation problems with this approach, partly due to its ignoring gender blindness and gender biased attitudes.

Intersectionality is a key concept in gender studies programs and literature ([McCall, 2005](#); Phoenix, 2006; [Verloo, 2006](#)). Social categories such as gender, race, class, and sexuality are framed as inextricably interconnected in the production of social inclusion and exclusion (Crenshaw, 1997). However, as Holvino (2010) notes, intersectionality is not well acknowledged by organization studies and/or organization change scholars. A disproportionate amount of attention is paid to glass ceilings and work-life balance, which are biased (even if unintentionally) toward white, middle-class, heterosexual women. Without question, such women are the most likely beneficiaries of glass ceiling projects, part-time work arrangements, flexible leave policies, and teleworking projects. These kinds of change projects target the classic nuclear family rather than lone mothers. They also fail to focus on the concerns

of working-class women, ethnic/racial minority women, and/or lesbians. Gender change projects in organizations need urgently to address the implications of race, gender, class, ethnicity, sexuality, and nation when discussing equality and fairness in organizations (Holvino, 2010).

The issue of *voice* is a long-time feminist issue that refers to the structural involvement of women in agenda-setting and decision-making. It draws attention to a 'woman's point of view' (or feminist standpoint) and urges its inclusion when deciding on which changes to pursue. While workers' representation is important relative to an organizational change agenda, the voices of women have been channeled to trade unions and work councils where support for gender equality and diversity has been lacking. The equality project within trade unions is far from completed (Kirton and Greene, 2005) and workplace democracy remains a utopian goal. Yet, the inclusion of voices that articulate and defend (intersectional) feminist positions is a necessity if gender equality is to be achieved in organizations. One way to strengthen the voice of women in agenda-setting and decision-making is through creating gender equality infrastructures such as equality/diversity departments, taskforces, and coordinators. The potential of such units or officials to realize gender change is high but it also depends on their authority to make things happen (Benschop and Verloo, 2002; Kalev et al., 2006). Furthermore, the ability and commitment to ally with women's and other groups and experts are required.

A FORWARD LOOKING STRATEGY: GENDERXCHANGE

Further development of strategies for gender equality in organization change theory and gender theory are urgently needed. What currently appears as the more promising approaches – gender mainstreaming and post equity – nevertheless inadequately address many impediments to change. Among those impediments are: the managerialist tendency of planned change, the need for simultaneous short and long-term agendas for change, the issue of resistance, the need to address gender-related emotions and attitudes, the intersectionality of multiple inequalities, and the inclusion and voice of all stakeholders, not only particular categories of women.

We end the chapter with an outline of a new approach to accommodate many of these issues. We propose a *genderXchange strategy* that takes a political approach to change and frames change as a socially accomplished, dynamic, and contextual process with many actors and interests at play. In the process, ample time should be dedicated to establishing constructive relations between gender equality experts and organization change agents and addressing individual attitudes and emotions that may obstruct gender change projects. The strategy requires activists to address both the individual and structural levels in order to organize needed systemic transformations. It requires development of a flexible planned change process with many feedback loops to deal with unforeseen developments that will occur during transformation. The planning process needs to be as democratic and participatory as possible to include the voices of all who are affected by gender change and to avoid the pitfalls of managerialism.

Active involvement of all affected parties should lower the odds of resistance, an effect that will be facilitated by having both short and long-term agendas. As for

content, the approach must deal with intersectionality by developing a complex project that goes beyond gender equality alone. In organization studies, debates about intersectionality are recent and organization scholars can learn about them from feminist theories and political science. A genderXchange project can produce *transversal politics* (Squires, 2007; Yuval-Davis, 2006) that recognize the need for dialogue between different standpoints, organize an encompassing commitment to a broad equality project, and differentiate between positioning, identity, and values so participants can negotiate a common political position from which to initiate and support genuine change.

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